

Tips on Writing Papers in L^AT_EX

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Abstract

We list some best practices and tips for writing technical papers in L^AT_EX.

Index Terms

Tips, suggestions, best practices.

I. GENERAL

Please see the tex file for actual implementation of the examples in this note. You will not learn anything by just reading the pdf file. This tex file includes some of the more commonly used packages and settings. It also illustrates the use of some packages, e.g., the enumitem package allows customization of the item listing. For details, read the documentation of the packages for different options.

- 1) Windows tex distribution: MiKTeX.
- 2) There are many good L^AT_EX tutorials online. A good starting point is <http://tobi.oetiker.ch/lshort/lshort.pdf>.
- 3) There are many tex editors you can use. I recommend TeXstudio, TeXnicCenter or Atom (with Git integration). You can also make use of Overleaf.
- 4) Use IEEEtran draftcls as in this tex file for drafts (editing stage). See also <http://www.michaelshell.org/tex/ieeetran/> for faqs.
- 5) I recommend the use of pdf_latex instead of latex. This means your figures should be in pdf or png format instead of eps. The reason is that typical dvi viewers are not very stable and responsive. However, if you insist on using latex, that is also fine. You can use the latexmk toolchain ("latexmk -synctex=1 -interaction=nonstopmode -file-line-error -pdf") to automatically perform the necessary multiple pdf_latex runs.

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- 6) Together with pdflatex, I recommend the use of SumatraPDF as the viewer. This allows you to use synctex, which lets you sync the pdf file to your tex file (double-clicking in the pdf file brings you directly to the right place in the tex file and vice versa when opening pdf from tex).
- 7) After running pdflatex or latexmk, **please look through the warnings and resolve them.** These are very helpful to catch errors like defining same labels multiple times.
- 8) I have provided a preamble.tex that you can include into your tex file using the \input command (see the beginning of this tex file). This file includes all the commonly used packages, declarations and aliases. **Look through the preamble.tex file first before you define your own newcommands to avoid duplication. The most updated preamble.tex file is always available on the shared Google Drive.** I will always use the most updated preamble.tex file, so there is no need for you to send me a copy. If you find some useful things to add to preamble.tex, please let me know.
- 9) You can use this tex file as a starting template when writing your papers.
- 10) Share your tex files with me through Google Drive or Overleaf. You can also host your files in a private Gitlab or Github repository and add me as a collaborator. The advantage of using git is you gain automatic version control.
- 11) Upload all references you have used in your paper to Google Drive, except for books. If you have referenced a paper, you should have at least read its abstract and the relevant parts that you have referenced.
- 12) Please ensure that you embed all your fonts into the pdf before you submit to a journal or conference.

II. LABELS

- (a) Use meaningful labels for your sections, equations, inequalities, figures, tables, and others. For example, use something like “sect:Labels” to label your section so that you know that this label is for a section. Later on in your text, you can then easily refer to it via something like “Section II”. Similarly, I use “eq:Meaningful_Name”, “ineq:Meaningful_Name”, “fig:Meaningful_Name” to label equations, inequalities, and figures.
- (b) Tip: items can also be labeled! Example is this reference (b).
- (c) Do not over label! For equations, tables, figures and most “objects”, we usually label only those that we need to refer to in another part of the text. In some cases, you may also

label important equations although you may not refer to these in any part of your text. This makes it easier for readers to refer to your equations. However, do this judiciously.

- (d) You should try to use the `cleveref` package to reference labels. It is smart enough to know what you are referencing, e.g., Section I, Sections I to III, (1) all use the same `cref` command. Otherwise, you have put a tilde like “Section I” to avoid line breaks immediately after “Section”.

III. EQUATIONS

- 1) There are many ways to write equations, but I find that you really only need to use either the `align` or `align*` environments provided by `amsmath`. The environment `align` will have equation numbers at every line and `align*` has no equation numbers. See the tips on labeling to decide when to use `align` and `align*`. Examples are:

$$X = \sum_{i=1}^n y_i \tag{1}$$

$$= z$$

$$= w, \tag{2}$$

and

$$X = \int_a^b f(x) \, dx$$

$$= z$$

$$= w.$$

Another example is

$$\Lambda_{\text{SGLR}}(k, t) = \max \{ \Lambda(k, t), \Lambda_n(k, t) \}, \tag{3}$$

$$\tau_{\text{SGLR}}(b) = \min \{ \tau(b), \tau_n(b) \}, \tag{4}$$

$$\tau_{\text{W-SGLR}}(b) = \min \{ \tilde{\tau}(b), \tilde{\tau}_n(b) \}, \tag{5}$$

$$\Phi_i = \tau_{\text{W-SGLR}}(b) + i^2, \text{ for } i = 1, \dots, N, \tag{6}$$

$$\tilde{\mathbf{C}} = \text{one_hot} \left(\tilde{\mathbf{L}} \right). \tag{7}$$

Note when punctuation marks like “,” and “.” are required in the equations. Observe also how text is written in math environments.

- 2) Please put `&` before the binary operators like `=`, `\leq` and `\geq`. You can see why by comparing the following example with that above. Do you see that the spacing behind `=` is now missing?

$$\begin{aligned} X &= \int_a^b f(x) \, dx \\ &= z \\ &= w. \end{aligned}$$

- 3) Do not write something like

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=1}^n y_i \\ &= z \\ &= w, \end{aligned}$$

and therefore, we have

$$x + y = w.$$

It should be written as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=1}^n y_i \\ &= z \\ &= w, \end{aligned}$$

and therefore, we have

$$x + y = w.$$

Alternatively, use the `\intertext` command:

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=1}^n y_i \\ &= z \\ &= w, \end{aligned}$$

and therefore, we have

$$x + y = w.$$

- 4) When to use `\text` and `\mathrm`? From [tex.stackexchange](https://tex.stackexchange.com):

`\text{divides}` and `\mathrm{divides}` might give the same result, but they are conceptually different (and can actually be printed in different ways, depending on the math fonts used). Spaces in the argument of `\mathrm` are ignored, for example. Moreover, `\text` honors the font of the surrounding environment: it will print in italics in the statement of a theorem.

You should use `abc` if `abc` is part of a math symbol but `abc` if `abc` is text like in a conditional clause in a math environment.

- 5) Please refrain from using the “`$$ ... $$`” or “`\[ ... \]`” environment for equation displays. It makes the latex hard for me to read and makes it difficult to add labeling later on. Tip: If you find it a hassle to type the begin and end tags, set up some keyboard shortcuts! You should have keyboard shortcuts for the commonly used environments and commands to improve your writing efficiency. A useful tool is AutoHotkey.
- 6) An interesting package is `breqn`, which provides special equation environments that can perform line breaks *automatically*. This is very useful if you need to produce both single- and double-column versions of the same paper. Do check it out! As there are still some bugs in this package, I recommend that you use the `breqn` environments only for those few long equations, while sticking to `align` and `align*` for the rest.

IV. NEW COMMANDS

- 1) If you are using a group of symbols very frequently, define a new command for it. It is like writing a computer program. The new command can even take in an argument.
- 2) Example of a simple new command is $\mathbb{R}$. See the provided `preamble.tex` file for more examples!
- 3) Example of a more complex new command is $\mathbb{E}_0[f(X)]$. **As we use $\mathbb{E}$ and $\mathbb{P}$ very frequently, please figure out how I have defined these commands in the `preamble.tex` and use them appropriately.**

V. GRAPHICS

- 1) Put your figures into a subfolder called “Figures”.
- 2) You can set the graphics path in tex using “`\graphicspath`” (this has been done in the `preamble.tex` file). Then $\text{\LaTeX}$ will look for the right figure in the folder you have provided in the graphics path. See Fig. 1 for an example.

- 3) In Fig. 1, we use the subfigure environment to create Figs. 1a and 1b.
- 4) I highly recommend Ipe (<http://ipe.otfried.org/>) for preparing your graphics. The advantage is that you can directly input latex symbols into your graphics using Ipe. Graphics can be saved directly in pdf. For example, you can open tandem.pdf in the Figures folder using the Ipe program and edit that! If you use another graphics program, the font may not be the same as your latex document. In that case, you may need to use psfrag to replace your labels.
- 5) Please use “!htb” or “!htbp” as options in your figures environment.

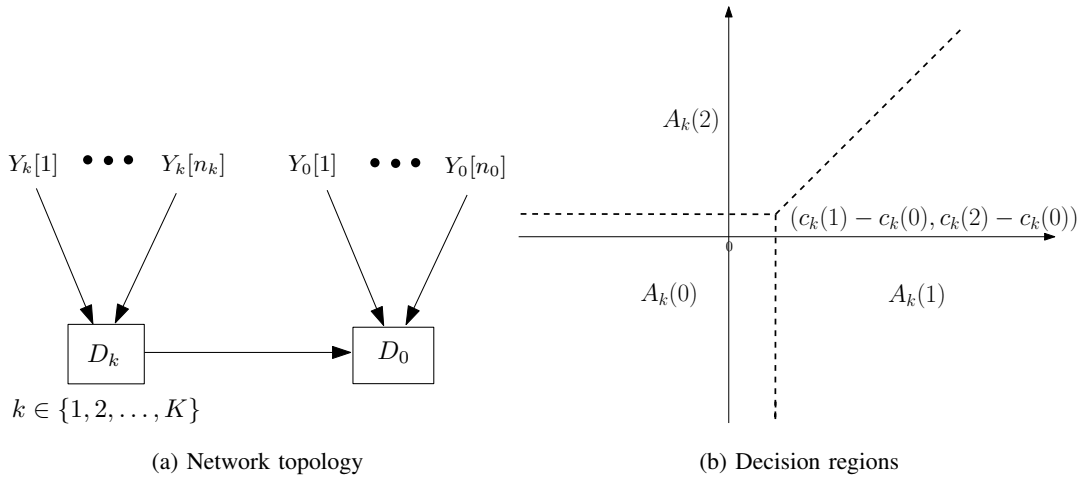


Fig. 1. A tandem network and its decision regions.

VI. PAPER EDITING PROCESS

- 1) After you have written your paper, put it aside for a day and revise it with a fresh mind in order to improve it. **This includes checking the bibliography for errors.** See Section VIII.
- 2) Please send me your paper for editing only after you have gone over it **several times** to correct any errors and improve it. You should send the paper to me only after you feel fully satisfied with the version that you have. Typically, this will be the fourth or fifth version.
- 3) You can email me all the necessary files, upload to your Google Drive shared folder or share via Overleaf. I prefer the latter two approaches.
- 4) I will highlight my major edits in **blue** and **red**, where the latter color usually indicates something that requires your action or special attention. Please go through all my edits to check for errors (never assume that I am always correct; I do make errors too!). If you are

satisfied with an edit, remove the highlight and return the file to me, with your own edits highlighted in blue. We will iterate this process until the paper reaches a satisfactory stage.

- 5) Please note that sometimes **NOT** all my edits are highlighted. Those highlighted are for your attention and checking. Some are for you to compare with your previous version so that you can learn from the change. Do not manually transfer the changes to your previous tex file. Use the tex file I send you for your next iteration.

VII. RESPONDING TO PAPER REVIEWS

- 1) You can use the response.tex as a starting template. I have defined some useful environments for use there in your responses to reviewers' comments.
- 2) Check out the use of the packages catchfilebetween tags and xr (or xr-hyper if the hyperref package is used). These packages make life much easier when you need to cross-reference a label or citation from your manuscript tex file in your response file. It also allows you to quote a chunk of tex directly from your manuscript tex file. How cool is that?
- 3) In the response.tex file, replace manuscript-filename with your .tex filename (without the ".tex"). Add tags in your .tex file to reproduce the same chunk between the tags in your response. E.g., if you add the tags in your tex file:

```
%<*tag:NP>
```

```
Therefore, we have shown that  $P \neq NP$ .
```

```
%</tag:NP>
```

and use “\revision{tag:NP}” in your response.tex, the sentence between the two tags will be quoted in your response. This ensures that whatever changes you make in the tex file are reflected in the response.

VIII. BIBLIOGRAPHY

- 1) Use bibtex to keep track of your references.
- 2) Use a meaningful system for your bibtex keys. For example, a common practice is to use the first 3 letters of the first 3 authors' last name followed by the year the paper is published, e.g., “LenTayQui:J16”.
- 3) Use the IEEEabrv.bib file. Read the file to understand how it works. I have also provided a StringDefinitions.bib that contains some of the conferences relevant to our research areas.
- 4) Programs like JabRef can help you to organize your bib library.

5) In the following, I list examples of correct or preferred reference citations as well as bad citations in the IEEEtran bibliographystyle. Please refer to refs.bib to see the bib entries. Can you tell the difference between the correct citation and each of the bad citations?

(i) Example of correct journal citation:

- M. Leng, W. P. Tay, F. Quitin, C. Cheng, S. G. Razul, and C. M. S. See, “Anchor-aided joint localization and synchronization using SOOP: Theory and experiments,” *IEEE Trans. Wireless Commun.*, vol. 15, no. 11, pp. 7670 – 7685, Nov. 2016

(ii) Examples of bad journal citation:

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- M. Leng, W. P. Tay, F. Quitin, C. Cheng, S. G. Razul, and C. M. S. See, “Anchor-aided joint localization and synchronization using SOOP: Theory and experiments,” *IEEE Transactions on Wireless Communications*, vol. 15, no. 11, pp. 7670 – 7685, Nov. 2016 [Note: If you do not want to use standard abbreviations in the journal name, you have to be consistent and do this for ALL journals and conferences.]
- M. Leng, W. P. Tay, F. Quitin, C. Cheng, S. G. Razul, and C. M. S. See, “Anchor-aided joint localization and synchronization using SOOP: Theory and experiments,” *IEEE trans. wireless commun.*, vol. 15, no. 11, pp. 7670 – 7685, Nov. 2016

(iii) Examples of correct conference citation:

- M. Sun and W. P. Tay, “Privacy-preserving nonparametric decentralized detection,” in *Proc. IEEE Int. Conf. Acoustics, Speech, and Signal Processing*, Shanghai, China, Mar. 2016
- M. Leng, F. Quitin, C. Cheng, W. P. Tay, S. G. Razul, and C. M. S. See, “Joint navigation and synchronization using SOOP in GPS-denied environments: Algorithm and empirical study,” in *Proc. Sensor Signal Processing for Defence Conf.*, Edinburgh, UK, Sep. 2015

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- M. Leng, F. Quitin, C. Cheng, W. P. Tay, S. G. Razul, and C. M. S. See, “Joint navigation and synchronization using SOOP in GPS-denied environments: Algorithm and empirical study,” in *Proc. 5th Sensor Signal Processing*

for *Defence Conf.*, Edinburgh, UK, Sep. 2015 [Note: If you want to keep the “5th”, you have to be consistent and do this for ALL conferences.]

- M. Leng, F. Quitin, C. Cheng, W. P. Tay, S. G. Razul, and C. M. S. See, “Joint navigation and synchronization using SOOP in GPS-denied environments: Algorithm and empirical study,” in *Proc. Sensor Signal Processing for Defence Conf.*, Sep. 2015

(v) Example of correct book citation:

- D. Stroock, *Probability Theory: An Analytic View*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1993

(vi) Examples of bad book citation:

- D. Stroock, *Probability Theory: an Analytic View*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1993
- D. Stroock, *Probability Theory: An Analytic View*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge university press, 1993
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